

PHILOSOPHY

Overview

The philosophy major (33 credits) and minor (15 credits) offer Iowa State University students the opportunity to explore fundamental human questions through reflection and argumentation. Do we have free will? Can machines think? What makes actions right or wrong? What is the nature of knowledge and what can we hope to know? What does justice require, politically and economically? Philosophy classes explore answers to deep questions such as these, encouraging each student to develop and rationally defend their own views.

Philosophy offers a structured but flexible program to help students graduate on time while pursuing their interests. 2000-level courses introduce students to essential questions and methods of philosophical thought. In 3000-level courses, students engage in close examination of central topics in both contemporary thought and the history of philosophy. Seminars at the 4000-level offer the opportunity to study topics in-depth alongside a committed team of faculty and students.

Philosophy fosters skills of communication and critical thinking that are valuable across work, family, and civic life. The program equips students to logically analyze and develop new responses to the challenges faced by humanity. It also emphasizes clarity of thought and communication as part of rigorous engagement with both abstract and applied areas of thought. These skills of logical analysis, careful reading, original thought, and clear communication are in high demand across different fields of work and post-graduate study. Philosophy majors typically achieve some of the highest scores on standardized tests such as the LSAT and GRE and have mid-career salaries higher than many other majors.

Student Learning Outcomes

Upon graduation, students should be able to:

1. Explain central problems in key areas of philosophy, such as metaphysics, epistemology, ethics, logic, political philosophy, philosophy of language, and the philosophy of science.
2. Explain the views of historically important philosophers and place them in the context of significant philosophical movements.
3. Identify and critically evaluate arguments by developing objections and replies.
4. Communicate ideas and arguments, both orally and in writing, with clarity and precision.
5. Engage with different points of view with open-mindedness, intellectual curiosity, and a willingness to learn from the ideas and arguments of others.

Philosophy Degree Requirements

As majors in the College of Liberal Arts and Sciences, Philosophy students must meet College of Liberal Arts and Sciences (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/collegeofliberalartsandsciences/>) and university-wide requirements (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/collegescurricula/>) for graduation in addition to those stated below for the major.

The degree program in philosophy requires a minimum of 33 credits, plus the zero credit PHIL 4920 course. The following courses compose the core program of the major from which 15 credits shall be chosen. Additionally, two courses at the 4000 level or above (other than PHIL 4900 and PHIL 4920) are required.

Ethical Theory: At least one course required.		3
PHIL 3300	Ethical Theory	
PHIL 3350	Social and Political Philosophy	
PHIL 5350	Contemporary Political Philosophy	
History: Two courses required.		6
PHIL 3100	Ancient Philosophy	
PHIL 3140	17th Century Philosophy	
	or PHIL 3150 18th Century Philosophy	
Metaphysics: One course required.		3
PHIL 3640	Metaphysics: God, Minds, and Matter	
PHIL 3660	Knowledge, Rationality, and Evidence	
PHIL 3800	Philosophy of Science	
Logic: One course required.		3
PHIL 2070	Introduction to Symbolic Logic	
Graduating Senior Survey.		
PHIL 4920	Graduating Senior Survey	R
Additional courses in philosophy.		18
Total Credits		33

Students in all ISU majors must complete a three-credit course in U.S. Cultures and Communities and a three-credit course in International Perspectives. Check <http://www.registrar.iastate.edu/courses/div-ip-guide.html> for a list of approved courses. Discuss with your advisor how the two courses that you select can be applied to your graduation plan.

LAS majors require a minimum of 120 credits, **including a minimum of 45 credits at the 3000/4000 level**. Three of the required 45 3000+ level credits must be earned in a general education group outside the group of the major. You must also complete the LAS world language requirement and LAS career proficiency requirement.

According to the university-wide Communication Proficiency Grade Requirement (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#communicationproficiencypolicytext>), students must demonstrate their

communication proficiency by earning a grade of C or better in ENGL 2500.

Philosophy, B.A.

Freshman

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
PHIL 2010	3 Philosophy Choice	3
ENGL 1500	3 Social Science Choice	3
LIB 1600	1 Humanities Choice	3
Humanities Choice	3 Math Choice	3
Social Science Choice	3 World Language/Elective	4
World Language/Elective	4	
	17	16

Sophomore

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
PHIL 3100	3 PHIL 2070	3
ENGL 2500	3 PHIL 3140 or 3150	3
Philosophy Choice	3 Natural Science Choice	4
Humanities Choice	3 Social Science Choice	3
Natural Science Choice	4 Elective	2-3
	LAS 2030	1
	16	16-17

Junior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
PHIL 3300	3 Philosophy Choice - 3000/4000 Level	3
PHIL 3640 or 3800	3 Electives	12
Philosophy Choice	3	
Electives	6	
	15	15

Senior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
Philosophy Choice - 4000 Level	3 PHIL 4920	R
Philosophy Choice - 3000/4000 Level	3 Philosophy Choice - 4000 Level	3
Electives	6 Electives	10
	12	13

Minor in Philosophy

The department offers a minor in philosophy which may be earned by completing a total of 15 credits in philosophy. At least 9 credits must be in courses numbered 3000 or above (only 3 credits of which may be in PHIL 4900), and at least 3 credits must be taken at Iowa State University.

The minor must include at least 3 credits that are not used to meet any other department, college, or university requirement.

The Philosophy Undergraduate Minor is an LAS Minor. In addition to University policies governing minors (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#degreeplanningtext>), LAS minors require at least 6 credits in courses numbered 3000 and above, with a grade of C or higher.

MINOR IN ETHICS

The Department Philosophy and Religious Studies offers a minor in ethics. Ethics is the branch of human thought that addresses questions of human morality. It seeks to define right and wrong at the theoretical level and to guide action across diverse fields of practice. An ethics minor provides opportunities for students to develop an understanding of both the theoretical foundations and the practical applications of ethics. It serves students who wish to understand how ethical thought complements their chosen majors, but also students who have an interest in learning about ethics more generally.

The minor in ethics requires 15 credits; at least 6 credits must be in courses numbered 3000 or above. The minor must include at least 3 credits that are not used to meet any other department, college, or university requirement.

All students pursuing the minor in ethics must complete either PHIL 2300 Moral Theory and Practice or PHIL 3300 Ethical Theory. In addition, students must complete 6 credits of courses chosen from a list of Core Ethics courses, as well as 6 credits of Additional Ethics courses chosen from either the core ethics courses or a broader list of courses with a significant ethics focus. At least 3 credits must be taken at Iowa State University.

The Ethics Undergraduate Minor is an LAS Minor. In addition to University policies governing minors (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#degreeplanningtext>), LAS minors require at least 6 credits in courses numbered 3000 and above, with a grade of C or higher.

Students must take PHIL 2300 or PHIL 3300, or both.	3
6 credits from Core Ethics courses:	6
PHIL 2300	Moral Theory and Practice
PHIL 2350	Ethical Issues in a Diverse Society
PHIL 3200	Existentialism
PHIL 3300	Ethical Theory
PHIL 3310	Moral Problems in Medicine
PHIL 3320	Philosophy of Law
PHIL 3340	Environmental Ethics
PHIL 3350	Social and Political Philosophy
	or PHIL 5350 Contemporary Political Philosophy
PHIL 3360	Bioethics and Biotechnology

PHIL 3430	Ethics of Computing and Artificial Intelligence
PHIL 4300	Value Theory
PHIL 4500	Agency and Free Will
6 credits additional ethics courses from the Core Ethics courses or from the Additional Ethics courses below:	
ARTGR 4890	Design Ethics
ACCT 4890	Sustainability Reporting
AI 2020	Ethical Design, Use, and Impact of AI
ANTHR 2200	Globalization and Sustainability
ANTHR 2300	Globalization and the Human Condition
CJ 4700	Ethical Issues in Criminal Justice
CPRE 2340	Legal, Professional, and Ethical Issues in Cyber Systems
ECON 3210	Economics of Discrimination
ECON 3620	Applied Ethics in Agricultural Business
EDUC 2050	Social Foundations of Education in the United States: Early Childhood and Elementary Education
EDUC 4050	Teaching and Learning in a Pluralistic Society: Early Childhood and Elementary
EDUC 4810	Philosophy of Education
or EDUC 5810	Philosophy of Education
EE 3880	Sustainable Engineering and International Development
ENTSP 4100	Social Entrepreneurship
GLOBE 2200	Globalization and Sustainability
JLMC 4620	Media Ethics, Freedom, Responsibility
ME 4120	Ethical Responsibilities of a Practicing Engineer
MGMT 3720	Ethical and Responsible Management
MGMT 4190	Social Responsibility of Business
NREM 4600	Controversies in Natural Resource Management
NS 4120	Leadership and Ethics
PHIL 3380	Feminist Philosophy
PHIL 3390	Liberty and Law in America
POLS 2350	Introduction to Ethics and Western Political Thought
POLS 4800	Ethics and Public Policy
RELIG 3600	Religion and Ethics
RELIG 3700	Religion and Politics
RELIG 3800	Catholic Social Thought
SOC 3340	Politics and Society
SOC 3620	Applied Ethics in Agricultural and Rural Development

Total Credits**15**

Philosophy - Graduate Study

The department offers work for a graduate minor in philosophy. For those taking the M.A. or M.S., the minor requirement is two courses above 3000 (but not PHIL 4900), each taken in conjunction with PHIL 5900. For those taking the Ph.D., the requirement is four courses above 3000, at least one of which is above 4000 (but not PHIL 4900), each taken in conjunction with PHIL 5900. Interested students should ask the chair to assign a minor advisor.

The department participates in the interdepartmental program in general graduate studies.